

Community Sessions

Community Sessions

Structured facilitation guides for NGO practitioners running community workshops that turn systems understanding into collective action.

The systems thinking tool helps a community understand their situation. These sessions are where they do something about it.

Map It and Reverse It are structured facilitation guides for NGO practitioners running community workshops. Each session builds on the last: Map It produces a shared diagram of how the community's ecological and social problems connect and reinforce each other. Reverse It uses that diagram to find where an intervention could actually shift the system.

Both guides are designed to be run by a facilitating NGO with moderate facilitation experience. They work alongside the EcoTipping Points systems thinking framework, not as a replacement for local knowledge: the community's own understanding of their situation is what drives the process. Slide decks for each session are available on the Map It and Reverse It pages; review them before you run each session, not for the first time in the room with the community members.

Map It

A community mapping session produces a shared diagram showing how ecological and social problems connect and reinforce each other, and where a change might find traction.

Reverse It

This session uses the map the community built to find where and how to intervene. You're working toward a shortlist of 1–3 candidate interventions specific enough to plan a first step.

Map It

A structured facilitation guide for producing a shared diagram of how a community's ecological and social problems connect and reinforce each other.

Session Guide

A printable version of this page to take into the field.

Step-by-step walkthrough of a real vicious cycle map, built from an ETP case story.

A community mapping session produces a shared diagram showing how the community's ecological and social problems connect and reinforce each other, and where a change might find traction. Collective knowledge is essential, but building it together in the room creates shared understanding and anchors commitment to whatever comes next. People who helped draw the map will engage with it differently than people who were handed one.

1. Agree on the problem

Before gathering losses, get the group to a shared starting point. This takes ten minutes and prevents the session from fracturing into separate threads later.

Ask: "In one sentence, what is the main problem this community is facing?" Write responses. If they diverge, find the common thread and name it. Write it at the top of the paper as the agreed framing for the session.

2. Open with loss, not process

Don't explain the exercise upfront. Start with a concrete question about lived experience:

Write responses on the paper as they come. Don't organize yet. Invite different perspectives: what fishing families lost may differ from what farming households lost; what elders remember may differ from what younger people have seen. Make sure all of it goes on the paper: ecological losses and social ones together.

If the group is quiet, try: "What did your parents have access to that you don't?"

Then push back in time further. Ask about changes that happened before the visible decline, in the decades leading up to it: new land management practices, shifts in ownership, industries or markets that arrived and changed how people used the land or water. External pressures (government policies, new technologies, outside economic forces) belong on this list as much as local ones. Some of the earliest shifts are where the story actually starts.

3. Surface the pressures

Once you have a list of losses, ask about causes. No cause is too large or too small:

Keep collecting on the same paper without organizing. People typically name external causes first: new industries, government land decisions, outside markets. Acknowledge these as real. Then ask: "And within the community, is there anything happening here that's also contributing?"

4. Build the map

Pick one item, usually a core resource loss, and draw it in the center. Then ask:

Draw the earliest cause they identify. Then: "What happened next?" Draw the arrow forward. Repeat this, working chronologically toward the present. The diagram grows as the story proceeds, and that's intentional: participants should see the chain extending as the session goes on.

Arrows can lead in multiple directions from the same event. They can also loop back to something already in the chain, which is when the diagram starts showing why things keep getting worse.

No impact is too small to map. Ecological changes spread across both the ecosystem and the social system. When participants mention something that seems minor, add it.

Facilitator Tip

When a vicious cycle first becomes visible in the diagram, stop and name it explicitly. "So this loops back to here, which means the problem feeds itself. That's the pattern we're looking for." These reinforcing loops are often the most important places to break.

The session is working when someone in the room says "so it keeps getting worse because..." That's the feedback loop becoming visible.

If the group gets stuck: "Does this connect to anything else on the board?" or "Is there anything important that's missing from this picture?"

Once the diagram feels complete, ask participants to identify the earliest cause in the chain: the event or change that started the whole sequence. Circle it. This is the negative tipping point: the moment the system began moving in the wrong direction. Label it. You'll return to it in the next session.

Facilitator Tip

Three things are distinct on this diagram: the negative tipping point (where the system began to tip); the specific location in the chain where the human-nature connection broke; and the nodes where a positive intervention might work. They often overlap, but not always. Knowing which is which matters for Reverse It.

5. Test and validate

Before closing, make sure the complete diagram is on the paper. Then read it back:

Give people explicit permission to correct it. Then ask: "Is there anything on this map that the community has some ability to change, even partially?" Circle those nodes lightly. This is a positive note to end on: the group has found places where they might have some traction.

Close with a brief, open question: "Is there anything in this diagram that we could change?" Don't take it further here. Just let the answers sit. That's the question Reverse It is built to answer.

Facilitator Note

This question appears again at the start of Reverse It. That's intentional; it's a bridge, not a repetition. Ending Map It with it open plants the question before the group has a framework to answer it. Reverse It gives them that framework.

6. Close and distribute

Before people leave, name what the group accomplished: they've described their situation as a connected system rather than a list of separate problems, and that's what points toward where a change could matter.

The map should leave the room with participants. A shared diagram they can hold, study, and show to others does work that a map on the facilitator's laptop cannot. Photograph the original at the end of the session. If time allows, redraw a clean version before distributing, especially if the map got complicated. A clear layout, with vicious cycles and the tipping point visually legible, helps people keep thinking between sessions.

Watch For

Deference to one or two voices. Try breaking into smaller groups for part of the discussion. Ask quieter participants directly: "What do you see from your experience?"

Politeness masking disagreement. In many communities, people will nod or raise hands to be polite without intending to act. Don't read silence as agreement. Pause, ask the quiet people, and when someone nods, ask what the nod means.

Impatience for solutions. Acknowledge the urgency: "I know it feels slow to spend time mapping when things are urgent. What we're trying to avoid is acting fast in the wrong place."

A map that gets too complicated. Pull back: "If you had to identify just three or four things driving the decline, what would they be?" Some maps do get complex; that's not always a problem. But participants should be able to read it.

Materials Note

Large paper is ideal, but work with what's available: a whiteboard, a wall with sticky notes, or even a cleared patch of ground and sticks.

Two marker colors help distinguish problems from connections, but one color works.

Photograph the map at the end of the session and print before the next one. Printed copies for distribution matter. A shared map that participants can hold and show to others does work that a map on the facilitator's laptop cannot.

Before committing to an intervention, use the Constraints Worksheet to test your approach against real conditions. ↓ [Download the Constraints Worksheet](#)

Reverse It

A structured facilitation guide for using the community map to find where and how to intervene, working toward a shortlist of candidate interventions specific enough to plan a first step.

Session Guide

A printable version of this page to take into the field.

Step-by-step walkthrough of how a real community identified and chose their lever.

This session uses the map the community built to find where and how to intervene. There's no formula: every community faces a different set of environmental and social challenges. But this framework will guide the community in their search for strategies that are forceful and doable: a vicious cycle mapped, levers strong enough to turn things around identified, and a test of whether the community has the resources and commitment to pull it off.

You're working toward a shortlist of 1–3 candidate interventions specific enough to plan a first step.

1. Reconnect to the map

Distribute printed copies of the Map It diagram. Having the map in hand changes the dynamic: participants can annotate, point, and return to it throughout the session.

Walk through it briefly. Don't assume people remember the previous session:

Return to those circled nodes from the Map It session. Invite participants to add any new ones they've thought about since. That's where this session begins.

2. Look for where the connection broke

Before the decline started, the ecosystem and community usually supported each other. Something broke that relationship: a new market, a technology, outside pressure, a policy change. Those break points are worth locating precisely.

Ask:

Mark those points. There may be several; in a system that has spiralled deeply, an early break often gets amplified by reinforcing cycles that came later. Look for breaks at different points in the chain, not just the earliest one.

Then ask which of them the community can actually influence. The overlap between "where the connection broke" and "where we have agency" is the shortlist.

This overlap is a useful starting point for finding levers. Some levers will map directly to where the break happened. Others will work at different points in the chain. The goal is to find the places with the most pull on the whole system.

3. Ask if someone nearby already solved this

Before designing anything, ask:

If yes, study it before inventing anything. A solution developed within the same ecological and social constraints (same soils, same seasons, same pressures) is often more credible and easier to adopt than one brought in from elsewhere.

4. Introduce patterns from similar cases

Bring in ETP case material as analogy, not prescription. For each candidate intervention point, ask whether any ETP case looks structurally similar:

- Resource extracted faster than it regenerates (including reef and fish populations): Apo Island. Fishers agreed on two rules: a permanent no-take sanctuary covering a fifth of the reef, and a ban on destructive fishing methods. Fish populations recovered within a few years, and the surrounding fishery improved because the protected area was producing more fish than before. The community gave the reef the conditions to restore itself.
- Community benefit disconnected from ecological health: Khao Din. Restructure farming so the land's health and the family's income move together.
- Dependence on external inputs: Punukula. Replace cash inputs with labor and local knowledge.
- Degraded water or soil: Gopalpura. Restore the infrastructure that natural cycles depend on to support community life.

The question isn't "do what they did." It's: what structural move made this work, and is that move available here?

5. Generate lever candidates

Ask the group to identify 3–5 specific things the community could do that might shift the system. Push past the obvious: the most effective lever often isn't the most visible one. Encourage candidates that work with what the ecosystem can do on its own, given the right conditions.

Useful prompts:

A lever that draws on ecological memory (on species behaviors and ecosystem cycles the community already understands) is often more durable than one that requires new outside knowledge. Nature's own self-healing capacity is one of the most powerful forces available; the facilitator's job is to help the group find where to let it through.

Facilitator Tip

If you already have a sense of what the lever should be, hold it back. Share it only after the group has generated its own candidates. Present it as one more option to evaluate. A process that performs participation while seeking ratification is the most common failure mode in this work.

6. Test each candidate

Run 3–5 candidates through a group feasibility check. The questions below apply to rules, collective agreements, restoration practices, governance changes, and other types of initiatives:

- Can people tell whether this is being followed or carried out?
- Can the community track progress without sustained outside help?
- Can it be adapted as conditions change, using knowledge that already exists here?
- Does it require governance structures that don't yet exist?
- Can the community provide the time, energy, and resources to carry it out?
- Will it involve short-term sacrifices that create excessive burdens for some members? If so, how will those burdens be shared?
- Does the community have the leadership needed to manage and enforce commitments?
- Starting small: can you run a pilot version that builds commitment and resources before scaling up?
- Does this change who benefits from the resource, or does it just change how things are done while leaving the same people in control?

7. Rank and close

Help the group rank candidates on three dimensions: how many loops in the system does this affect (leverage), how significantly does it shift the system dynamic (impact), and what can they realistically start (feasibility). Give weight to candidates that harness natural recovery processes (what the land or water will do if given the chance).

Close with:

Watch For

The group jumps to solutions early. Let them name the solution, then run it through the feasibility check rather than shutting down the energy.

Every option feels too small. Usually means the group has correctly identified that real change requires structural shifts that feel politically impossible. Ask: "Given that, what's a move that still points in that direction?"

The group can't agree. Either the analysis wasn't complete (go back to the map) or there's a real conflict of interest that hasn't surfaced yet. Ask: "What's the disagreement actually about?"

You already know what the lever should be. Share it only after the group has generated its own candidates, and present it as one more option to evaluate. Running a process that performs participation while actually seeking ratification is the most common failure mode in this work.

Materials Note

Bring printed copies of the Map It diagram and distribute them at the start of the session. A map participants can hold and mark up changes the dynamic.